



BASIC PHONES

Phones priced below Rs 5,000 formed the basic phone category. We had phones from Alcatel, LG, Bird, Nokia, Benq and Philips. BenQ had three phones in the category, while Alcatel came up with two compact little contenders. Nokia could only manage to get its 1100 phones in this category. Philips sent in its stylish-looking 330 phone for the masses.



Alcatel Onetouch 331
Rating: **A**
Price: Rs 2,990

Alcatel's Onetouch 331 is very compact—it's no bigger than a Cadbury's Five-star chocolate bar, and looks great in its ivory white cover with a light orange backlight. However, the Onetouch 320 sports dated looks akin to the earlier 3 series of phones from Nokia, such as the Nokia 3320.

BenQ's S620i sports a pearl-finished plastic body, whereas the S630i is all silvery. Of the two, the S630i stands out as a better finished product. Both are quite bulky as compared to the Philips 330, which despite being a flip-phone is quite slim.

BenQ does have a slick contender in the form of the M560G. It's feature-rich, and is much better than its other two siblings in terms of design and overall appeal.

The Philips 330 offers good functionality and probably was the best looking flip phone of the

lot—its chrome finish sets it apart from the rest.

The 1100 from Nokia made quite an impression with its design and super slick usability. It packs in a variety of accessories ranging from hard plastic for the casing, rubber keys and rubber inserts on the side that provide a firm grip.

Bird, a little known Chinese manufacturer, had the S1160 in the Basic phones category. It's a flip model, treated in silver and intelligently designed. However, it does not evoke the rugged feel associated with phones in this category, neither is it aesthetic in its appeal.

LG, with its G1500, is another Nokia clone with a Korean touch. This compact little phone combines good functionality with a decent design.

Nokia's 1100 takes the lead when it comes to usability. Its rubber keys are a little hard to press but their placement is perfect. The tried and tested navigation from the 3310 also

makes its way to the 1100, but with a small difference—the buttons are rearranged. Its menu is easy to use, and menu items are logically grouped—something the rest of the competition hasn't given a thought to.

Alcatel's Onetouch 331 comes a close second, but lacks Nokia's menu-structuring finesse. It employs a two-dimensional joystick to browse the menu. On the other hand, the Alcatel 320 is quite cumbersome and uses rubber keys similar to those on the Nokia 3350, which are not so user-friendly.

Philips uses a slim design and small form factor to make the 330 a pleasure to use. In fact, it was the second lightest phone in this category—the lightest being Alcatel's 331. However, it may be some time before you get used to the Philips 330's menu structure.

A good keypad, small form factor, and a weight of 80 gm placed BenQ's M560G third in the usability department. The other two BenQ models lack that very feel that goes into the making of a good phone.

LG's 1500 also scored high on the usability aspect. People making the switch from Nokia will find its menu easy to navigate. Its button placement, however, takes some getting used to.

On the messaging front, the Nokia 1100 still rules the roost—with a straightforward messaging system. The T9 predictive input is also superior to others—the models from Nokia and LG give you

the most relevant words first, whereas the Alcatels throw up all sorts of combinations, and ask you to 'help' choose the words. The other phone that equals Nokia's messaging ability is the LG G1500. BenQ's messaging interface also shouldn't pose a problem. Alcatel's messaging system, though, is a complete mess.

All these phones use monochrome displays, but not all of them have a resolution to match. Then there's the backlight to consider, which also makes a difference in monochrome displays. A green backlight does not put much strain on your eyes, while a blue backlight makes it difficult to read text. A white backlight is the coolest and makes reading the screen a much better job. The Nokia 1100, BenQ S620i and 630i, Bird S1160 and Alcatel 320 all use green backlights. The Philips 330



NOKIA 1100
Rating: **C+**
Price: Rs 4,699